rescripts that came to be transcribed in the second campaign of epigraphs. As against the first articulation of the ‘minor’ edicts, we now encounter a series of messages, of more than a hundred lines covering, in several instances, multiple rock surfaces. By common consent these are known as Ashoka’s major rock edicts, the word ‘major’ denoting the length and possibly the gravitas of the message. Collectively, the rendition appears like a finished and coherent anthology comprising fourteen edicts.

On the orders of the emperor, this set of edicts was transcribed in several places across India. At many of their locations they have survived well. The most extraordinary of these sites is Erragudi in Andhra, where we saw the first of Ashoka’s minor epigraphs—which graces the most easily accessible of the Erragudi rocks, inscribed on the lowest of the boulders. Five further boulders marked by similar scrawls are clustered across the hill face, the most imposing of these forming a precipice some six metres or more above the lowest. Many of the boulders crowd the eastern slope, their surfaces marked by a riot of Brahmi characters, some still easily decipherable, others only faintly visible. The varying conditions of preservation apart, what strikes the observer is the plethora of words. Their sprawl is seen best on the topmost rock, generally described as Boulder A, which has two inscribed faces. In general, the boulders show the ancient letters unevenly: sometimes, seven lines of writing cover 2.5 x 0.5 metres, while on the same rock five lines also crowd into a space only 1 metre long. The same message is also known to cover several rocks—one of the edicts has twenty-nine lines on a single boulder (Boulder B), while the last seven lines are continued on another (Boulder C) which lies a few feet to its south.

Versions of the major edicts like the one at Erragudi appear on rocks at Girnar in Gujarat, at Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra in north-west Pakistan, at Kandahar in Afghanistan, and at Kalsi in Uttarakhand. In two places within Orissa—Dhauli and Jaugada—there is a complete set of edicts, though some of what is found on them differs from that on the axis from Pakistan